Gov essay: all three prompts

Summative, Mon Nov 2, period 2, 9:00, Room 506

Blue: thesis, memorize word for word Red: alternative perspective Green: analysis

How to use this

1. Read one prompt's page top to bottom.
2. Cover the draft and say the thesis out loud. Then say each body paragraph's evidence from memory.
3. Use the T E A tags: every body paragraph is Topic sentence, Evidence, Analysis.
4. Repeat for the other two prompts. In class you only write one.

The pattern every essay follows

Paragraph	What goes in it
1. Intro	3 context sentences, broad to narrow, then the thesis: **[Claim] because [Argument 1] and [Argument 2].**
2. Evidence 1	Topic sentence, specific evidence (events, people, documents, cases), analysis: "This shows... which proves..."
3. Evidence 2	Same as above, second argument.
4. Alternative perspective	"Critics argue...", their evidence, then "That is true to an extent. However..."
5. Conclusion	Thesis in new words, plus why it matters.

Rubric

- **A Knowing:** use at least 8 key terms correctly (popular sovereignty, checks and balances, Bill of Rights, amendment process, judicial review, Commerce Clause, Supremacy Clause, natural rights...).
- **B Investigating:** hand in the key terms sheet.
- **C Communicating:** full paragraphs, clear sentences.
- **D Thinking:** a line of reasoning, every body paragraph ends in analysis. Complexity: "to some extent," a counterargument, links across time (1787, 1865, today).

Which zine page each prompt uses

- **Prompt 1:** cover, Organized, three branches, Bill of Rights, Federalism.
- **Prompt 2:** Changing the Constitution, Judicial.
- **Prompt 3:** Judicial, Federalism, Changing the Constitution.

IF YOU GET THE NATURAL RIGHTS PROMPT

"To what extent did the Founders create a Constitution that successfully protects citizens' natural rights?" Use prompt 1's evidence. Thesis: to a large extent, because they divided power and the Bill of Rights protects life, liberty and property (the 5th Amendment says it word for word), but at first only for some Americans. Counter: slavery and who could vote. Answer: Article V, the 13th and 14th Amendments.

Prompt 1: The founders' goals

Collaborative essay practice, filled in

> **What were the goals and priorities of the founders in drafting and ratifying the Constitution?**

Step 1: analyze the prompt

In my own words: What did the people who wrote and approved the Constitution want it to do, and what mattered most to them?

- **Goals and priorities:** what they wanted, and what they cared about MOST (rank them)
- **Founders:** the delegates in Philadelphia, plus the Federalists and Antifederalists
- **Drafting:** writing it in 1787
- **Ratifying:** getting the states to approve it, 1787 to 1788, Bill of Rights 1791

Step 2: the options

Not a "to what extent" prompt, so the options are the three main answers you could give.

1 — 2 — 3

- **Option 1: A strong national government**, fix the Articles of Confederation, which were too weak to tax or keep order
- **Option 2: Protect liberty and prevent tyranny**, never repeat British rule
- **Option 3: Balance: strong but limited**, both at once, which is the strongest answer **← we argue this**

Step 3: evidence

#	Evidence	Which option it supports, and why
1	**Weak Articles of Confederation** Congress couldn't tax or keep order; Shays' Rebellion (1786) scared leaders.	Option 1: they needed a government strong enough to work.
2	**Preamble** "We the People" (popular sovereignty) and "secure the Blessings of Liberty".	Option 2: power comes from the people, and liberty is the goal.
3	**Separation of powers and checks and balances** Montesquieu: Articles I, II, III. Veto, 2/3 override, Senate confirms judges, House impeaches, Senate convicts with 2/3.	Option 3: power, but split so no one abuses it.
4	**Federalists' clauses** Hamilton and Madison: Necessary and Proper Clause, Commerce Clause, Supremacy Clause (Article VI).	Option 1: a stronger national government.
5	**Antifederalists and the Bill of Rights** They only ratified if promised a Bill of Rights (1791). 10th Amendment reserves powers to the states or the people.	Option 2: liberty was made a priority equal to power.

Step 4: draft

CONTEXT

After the Revolution, the Articles of Confederation left the national government too weak to tax, pay its debts or keep order. In 1787 delegates met in Philadelphia to write a new constitution. They had to balance two fears: a government too weak to function, and one so strong it would repeat British tyranny.

THESIS

The founders' main goal was a national government strong enough to work but limited enough that it could never become a tyranny, because they built it on Enlightenment ideas about natural rights and popular sovereignty, and because the Antifederalists forced them to protect individual liberty in a Bill of Rights.

EVIDENCE 1

T One major reason is that the founders built the government on Enlightenment ideas. E The Preamble begins with "We the People," showing popular sovereignty, and promises to "secure the Blessings of Liberty." Following Montesquieu, Articles I, II and III separate power into three branches, and checks and balances let each limit the others: the President can veto, Congress can override with 2/3 of both houses, and the Senate confirms judges. A This shows the founders cared more about preventing abuse of power than about speed. Splitting power three ways protects natural rights, which proves their priority was a limited government.

EVIDENCE 2

T Another reason is the debate between the Federalists and the Antifederalists. E Federalists like Hamilton and Madison wanted a stronger national government, with the Necessary and Proper Clause, the Commerce Clause and the Supremacy Clause in Article VI. Antifederalists feared it would abuse its power and would only ratify if promised a Bill of Rights, added in 1791, and the 10th Amendment reserved every other power to the states or the people. A This shows the final Constitution was a compromise: strong because of the Federalists and protective because of the Antifederalists, so liberty became a priority equal to power.

ALTERNATIVE PERSPECTIVE

T Critics argue that the founders mainly protected the property and power of wealthy white men. E Slavery stayed legal through the Three Fifths Compromise, and at first only some men could vote. A That is true to an extent. However, the founders also wrote Article V so the Constitution could change, which later allowed the 13th, 14th and 15th Amendments. Their priority was a government built to govern and built to grow.

CONCLUSION

The founders' priority was balance: enough power to govern, with enough limits to protect liberty. That balance is why the same framework still works more than 230 years later.

Prompt 2: How democracy evolved

Collaborative essay practice, filled in

> **How has American democracy evolved?**

Step 1: analyze the prompt

In my own words: How has the group of people who get a real voice and real rights in America changed since 1787, and what caused those changes?

- **Democracy:** government where power comes from the people (popular sovereignty)
- **Evolved:** changed over time; you must show a before and an after
- **American:** in the U.S., from 1787 to today

Step 2: the options

Not a "to what extent" prompt, so the options are three ways to describe the change.

1 — 2 — 3

- **Option 1: It expanded a lot**, from some white men to almost everyone
- **Option 2: It expanded, but slowly and unevenly**, real growth, but every step was fought for **← we argue this**
- **Option 3: It hasn't really changed**, the same groups are still held back

Step 3: evidence

#	Evidence	Which option it supports, and why
1	**Reconstruction Amendments, the "Second Founding"** 13th (1865) ended slavery, 14th (1868) citizenship, equal protection, due process, 15th (1870) no racial voting limits.	Options 1 and 2: rights reached formerly enslaved people.
2	**More voters** 19th Amendment: women vote. 26th: voting age 18.	Option 1: "We the People" grew.
3	**Hard amendment process** Article V: 2/3 of Congress, then 3/4 of the states. Only 27 of 11,000+ proposals passed.	Option 2: slow, but each change had wide support.
4	**Judicial review** Marbury v. Madison (1803) created it. Mapp v. Ohio (1961): illegal search evidence can't be used. U.S. v. Nixon (1974): the President must follow the law.	Option 1: courts made rights real.
5	**Uneven progress** 13th Amendment still allows slavery "as a punishment for crime" (documentary 13th, mass incarceration). Jim Crow blocked the 15th until the Voting Rights Act (1965).	Option 3, or the limit in Option 2.

Step 4: draft

CONTEXT

Democracy means power comes from the people, which the Constitution calls popular sovereignty. In 1787 the Constitution allowed slavery, and mostly only white men who owned property could vote. Since then, "We the People" has come to include far more Americans.

THESIS

American democracy has evolved from a system where only some white men had a voice into a much wider democracy, because amendments extended rights to more people and judicial review made those rights real. That evolution has been slow and uneven.

EVIDENCE 1

T One major reason democracy has grown is the amendment process. E The Reconstruction Amendments, the "Second Founding," changed who counts: the 13th ended slavery in 1865, the 14th gave citizenship, equal protection and due process in 1868, and the 15th banned racial limits on voting in 1870. Later, the 19th gave women the vote and the 26th lowered the voting age to 18. Each one needed 2/3 of Congress and 3/4 of the states, which is why only 27 of more than 11,000 proposals ever passed. A This shows democracy grew on purpose and with wide support. Because the process is so hard, every amendment that passed proves the country chose to expand who counts.

EVIDENCE 2

T Another reason is that the courts used judicial review to make rights real. E Marbury v. Madison (1803) gave courts the power to strike down laws. Mapp v. Ohio (1961) ruled that evidence from an illegal search can't be used, applying the 4th Amendment to the states through the 14th. U.S. v. Nixon (1974) showed that even the President must follow the law. A Rights on paper only matter when someone enforces them. Judicial review, which isn't even written in the Constitution, became one of the main ways democracy evolved.

ALTERNATIVE PERSPECTIVE

T Critics argue that American democracy hasn't truly evolved. E The 13th Amendment still allows slavery "as a punishment for crime," which the documentary 13th links to mass incarceration, and Jim Crow laws blocked the 15th Amendment for almost 100 years until the Voting Rights Act of 1965. A These show the evolution is incomplete, not absent. The same tools, amendments, courts and Congress, are what people used to fight back.

CONCLUSION

American democracy has grown far beyond 1787, but each step had to be fought for, and the work is still not finished.

Prompt 3: The 21st century

Collaborative essay practice, filled in

> **To what extent is the Constitution serving Americans' needs in the 21st century?**

Step 1: analyze the prompt

In my own words: How well does a document written in 1787 still protect Americans' rights and solve today's problems, like phones, privacy and AI?

- **To what extent:** how much: a spectrum, not yes or no
- **Constitution:** the 1787 document plus its 27 amendments and how courts read it
- **Serving needs:** protecting rights and letting government handle new problems
- **21st century:** today: smartphones, social media, AI

Step 2: the options

A "to what extent" prompt, so the options are places on a spectrum.

1 — 2 — 3

- **Option 1: To a great extent**, it adapts to everything
- **Option 2: To a large extent, with gaps**, flexible, but privacy depends on courts **← we argue this**
- **Option 3: Very little**, outdated and too hard to change

Step 3: evidence

#	Evidence	Which option it supports, and why
1	**Courts apply old rights to new tech** Riley v. California (2014): warrant to search a phone. Carpenter v. U.S. (2018): warrant for phone location data.	Option 1: the 4th Amendment covers phones without an amendment.
2	**Laws fit to new tech** Salazar v. Paramount Global (No. 25-459): the Video Privacy Protection Act and tracking pixels. Congress can rewrite a law if it disagrees.	Options 1 and 2: courts and Congress keep it current.
3	**Federalism and AI** Congress can regulate AI with the Commerce Clause (Article I). States pass their own AI laws as reserved powers (10th Amendment).	Option 1: the system splits up new problems.
4	**Federal vs California (March 2026)** The Department of Transportation sued California's Air Resources Board, saying the Supremacy Clause overrides its zero emission rules.	Option 2: the founders' balance still settles fights.
5	**Hard to change** Only 27 amendments; India 100+ since 1950, Mexico 700+ since 1917. Privacy isn't in the text. Presidents gain power through executive orders.	Option 3, or the gap in Option 2.

Step 4: draft

CONTEXT

The Constitution was written in 1787 for about 4 million people and a world without electricity. Today Americans live with smartphones, social media and artificial intelligence. That raises the question of whether a 230 year old document can still protect their rights.

THESIS

The Constitution serves Americans in the 21st century to a large extent, because courts can apply its broad principles to new technology and federalism with checks and balances lets the country handle problems like AI. However, its slow amendment process leaves modern rights like digital privacy depending on court decisions instead of the text.

EVIDENCE 1

T One major reason it still works is that the Supreme Court interprets the Constitution instead of waiting for amendments. E In Riley v. California (2014), the Court ruled police need a warrant to search a phone, and in Carpenter v. U.S. (2018) it required one for phone location data. Salazar v. Paramount Global shows courts fitting the Video Privacy Protection Act to tracking pixels, and Congress can rewrite the law if it disagrees. A This shows the founders' broad wording was an advantage. Judicial review and checks and balances let old rights cover new technology without passing an amendment.

EVIDENCE 2

T Another reason is federalism, which splits power between the nation and the states. E Congress can regulate AI through the Commerce Clause, while states pass their own AI laws as reserved powers under the 10th Amendment. In March 2026 the Department of Transportation sued California's Air Resources Board, claiming the Supremacy Clause overrides its zero emission rules, while California says it can set stricter standards. A This shows the balance between the Supremacy Clause and the 10th Amendment still works. States can experiment while national law keeps the country unified.

ALTERNATIVE PERSPECTIVE

T Critics argue the Constitution can't keep up. E Only 27 amendments have passed, while India has made more than 100 since 1950 and Mexico more than 700 since 1917. Privacy isn't written in the text, and presidents keep gaining power through executive orders and emergency powers. A That is valid to some extent, but the limits still hold: executive orders can't create laws or change spending, Congress keeps the power of the purse, and U.S. v. Nixon proved no President is above the law. Being hard to change keeps the Constitution stable.

CONCLUSION

The Constitution serves the 21st century to a large extent because its design is flexible, but protecting rights like privacy still depends on courts and Congress keeping up with technology.